NUNO FONTOURA · FREE RESOURCE

WORKSHEET

The Founder Bottleneck Audit

Every decision that runs through you is a tax on your business. Find them in one working week, then write the rules that take them off your desk.

■ Fillable PDF ■ 7 pages ■ 5 days + 2 hours

THE PROBLEM

The queue you can't see

You built the business and you know it best, so people ask you, and you answer. That pattern made sense when the team was small. As the business grows, it quietly becomes the constraint.

The constraint isn't your team, and it isn't the market. It's the invisible queue of decisions, approvals and sign-offs waiting for your attention every day. The gap isn't that you are the bottleneck personally: it's that the operating infrastructure hasn't kept pace with the business.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Waiting

Work stops until you reply. Your team learns that the fastest route is to ask you.

Reacting

Your day fills with issues as they arrive, and planned work is pushed back.

Repeating

The same question reaches you again and again, because the answer was never written down.

> **Many of those decisions and approvals should never reach your desk.** This audit finds them and takes them off your desk in four steps: track, question, write the rule, then test it.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKSHEET

1. **Track** every approval that reaches you for five working days (page 2).
2. **Audit** the list with three questions (page 3).
3. **Write a decision rule** for your top recurring approvals (pages 4–5).
4. **Test each rule** with its new owner, then check it is working (page 6).

Type straight into the grey fields on screen and save the file, or print it and write by hand.

STEP 1

Track every approval for five days

Log it as it happens, not from memory at the end of the day. Be honest: the point is to see the pattern.

DAY	WHAT WAS IT?	HOW LONG DID IT WAIT ON YOU?	DID IT NEED TO BE YOU?
Mon			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Tue			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Wed			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Thu			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No
Fri			☐ Yes ☐ No
			☐ Yes ☐ No

TOTAL APPROVALS THIS WEEK

TIME SPENT WAITING ON YOU rough estimate

THE PATTERN YOU NOTICE which approvals keep coming back?

THE ONE APPROVAL TO HAND OFF FIRST

STEP 2

The three-question audit

Go through your five-day log with these questions. If you answer yes to any of them, you've found a bottleneck.

1. What got delayed because it waited for you?

Projects or decisions that sat in limbo, not because the team couldn't act, but because they were waiting on you.

2. What did you approve that you didn't need to see?

Invoices under a threshold, supplier responses. If the outcome was the same whether you saw it or not, that's a bottleneck.

3. What do people ask you that they already know the answer to?

The most expensive category: the team doesn't trust its own judgement, usually because it has never been given the framework to use it.

> **THE INSIGHT**
>
> The real issue isn't delegation, it's doctrine. Your team isn't asking because they're unconfident; they don't know what "good" looks like without you in the room. The fix is codifying the judgement you carry in your head.

STEP 3

Write the rule

Take your top recurring approvals from Step 1 and write a decision rule for each: when it applies, the number that decides it, and who decides without you. A rule with no number in it isn't a rule, it's a suggestion.

DECISION RULE #1

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does this rule apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA the number that decides it

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

REVIEW DATE when it gets checked

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

TESTED WITH

TESTED ON

DECISION RULE #2

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does this rule apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA the number that decides it

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

REVIEW DATE when it gets checked

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

TESTED WITH

TESTED ON

DECISION RULE #3

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does this rule apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA the number that decides it

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

REVIEW DATE when it gets checked

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

TESTED WITH

TESTED ON

DECISION RULE #4

RECURRING APPROVAL what keeps landing on your desk?

TRIGGER when does this rule apply?

THRESHOLD OR CRITERIA the number that decides it

WHO DECIDES WITHOUT YOU

REVIEW DATE when it gets checked

WHAT "GOOD ENOUGH" LOOKS LIKE

TESTED WITH

TESTED ON

STEP 4

Test it, then let go

Hand each decision to its new owner and watch what they do with it once, before you let go completely. Share the finished rules where your team already works, not in a folder nobody opens.

WHEN A RULE IS WORKING

A decision rule is working when the outcome stops being reported to you as a decision, only as a summary. If people still check with you after the rule exists, it's either too vague, or nobody told them it exists.

- [ ] The rule has a number or a clear condition in it.
- [ ] It names one owner, not a team.
- [ ] The people it affects have seen it and know where it lives.
- [ ] It has a review date in the calendar.

NOTES

> This is the same discipline behind any reliable operation: whether someone new could run your core process from written instructions alone. A decision rule applies it to judgement calls instead of tasks.

THIS WEEK

Three actions

- [ ] **Track every approval for five days.** What it was, how long it waited, and whether it needed to be you.
- [ ] **Write a one-page decision rule for your top three approvals.** When to do it, when not to, and what "good enough" looks like.
- [ ] **Set a financial threshold your team can act within without asking.** The number matters less than having one.

OUR THRESHOLD e.g. up to 500 per decision

APPLIES TO

THE CLOSING QUESTION

If you were unavailable for 48 hours, what would grind to a halt?

That list is your audit.

Want to install this properly?

The audit covers one area. A discovery call looks at how the rest of your agency runs, so you can see where the next bottleneck is before it costs you.

Book a discovery call

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